

deaths in training and who prepared their trainee pilots best for combat. They disseminated knowledge of the principles of air combat worked out by Boelcke in 1916 (see page 82), and built up a body of highly skilled fighter pilots through careful selection of suitable individuals and their integration into fighter squadrons that fought in formation. The system did not begin to break down until the end of the war, when heavy losses forced Germany to throw thousands of inexperienced pilots into the fray.

There was always a tension in fighter units between the practical advantages of fighting in formation and the individualist temperament of most of the best pilots. Many of the early aces were often loners who developed their own secrets for success in combat that they were not eager to share with their colleagues. Werner Voss, for example, was a noted success as leader of Jasta 10 in 1917, but he would still head off on his own at dawn or dusk to track down enemy observation aircraft. Canadian pilot Billy Bishop for a time commanded Britain's 85th Squadron yet still fought his own personal war, recording most of his victories on solitary missions.

The French were the first to create self-consciously elite formations of fighter pilots,



GERVAIS RAOUL LUFBERY (1885–1918) was born in France but emigrated to the United States when he was six. Aged 19, he left to travel the world looking for adventure.

In 1912, he met French barnstormer Marc Pourpe, became his mechanic, and toured India and the East with Pourpe's exhibition flying show. When war broke out, Lufbery enlisted in the

AMERICAN ADVENTURER

Raoul Lufbery was revered by his men, who called him the "ace of aces"; his official tally was 16 victories.

the *Cigognes* (Storks). Originally a single squadron, N.3,

fighting at Verdun in 1916, the *Cigognes* had expanded to five squadrons by the following year. Despite being grouped together, however, top French pilots were often reluctant to fight as part of a team. One observer, Jean Villars, wrote that "the veterans want to hunt individually, through overconfidence and a desire to work on their own; the novices imitate them through vanity and ignorance."

RAOUL LUFBERY

French Foreign Legion – the only unit that foreigners could join – before teaming up with Pourpe again. When Pourpe was killed attempting a night landing, Lufbery graduated from mechanic to pilot, seeing his first service in 1915. In May 1916, he joined the Lafayette Escadrille, composed of American volunteers who had joined the French air force. He soon became its leading ace, as well as devising fighter tactics such as the Lufbery Circle, in which fliers formed a circle with each airplane protecting the one in front. In 1918 he joined the US Army Air Service as a combat instructor. He was killed in May 1918 after rushing to the aid of an inexperienced pilot fighting a German Rumpler. Lufbery's Nieuport caught fire in sight of the squadron airfield and he jumped to his death rather than burn alive.

High living

Fighter squadrons were never noted for their respect for formal discipline. During any lull in the action at the front, French elite pilots were in the habit of flying off to Paris, where they would be familiar figures in the best restaurants, always with attractive women in attendance and a stylish automobile parked outside.

British fighter squadrons were more noted for their drunken sprees and riotous behavior in the mess, a traditional way of coping with the fear and personal loss that were inseparable from combat. Yet under a firm squadron leader, such behavior would be kept carefully within limits.

Few pilots relished the idea of embarking on a dawn patrol with a stinking hangover – it tended to be an experience that a man would have once and never again.

The relaxed style of the fliers was hard for more traditional army officers to accept.

A US military intelligence report in 1917 identified indiscipline in the British flying corps as a problem caused by "the fact that the service, owing to its

FIGHTING THE COLD

Flying in open cockpits, cold was one of the major enemies all airmen faced. Wearing two layers of helmet and gloves, plus a leather coat and sheepskin boots, offered some protection. Goggles shielded the eyes against freezing wind, dust, and oil sprayed from the engine. Parachutes and oxygen equipment for high-altitude flight became available late in the war, but only for German airmen.

